# Preterite and imperfect in writing

## Imperfect -- WHAT WAS IT LIKE?

In storytelling:

1. Establish time, date, place
2. Describe characters and location
3. Describe what was customary or habitual
4. Describe what was going on at the particular point in time that the story takes place
5. Describe story events when there is a pause in the action

Other:

Actions without a definite beginning or end stated

Signal phrases:

**a menudo** (often)
**a veces** (sometimes)
**cada día** (every day)
**cada semana** (every week)
**cada mes** (every month)
**cada año** (every year)
**con frecuencia** (frequently)
**de vez en cuando** (from time to time)
**en aquella época** (at that time)
**frecuentemente** (frequently)
**generalmente** (usually)
**muchas veces** (many times)
**mucho** (a lot)
**nunca** (never)
**por un rato** (for a while)
**siempre** (always)
**tantas veces** (so many times)
**todas las semanas** (every week)
**todos los días** (every day)
**todo el tiempo** (all the time)
**varias veces** (several times)

## Preterite -- WHAT HAPPENED?

In storytelling:

1. Move the story line forward, narrate main events, and tell what happened
2. Summative statement of events of story

Other:

Actions that are seen as completed- given a specific number of times or a specific time period

Signal phrases:

**ayer** (yesterday)
**anteayer** (the day before yesterday)
**anoche** (last night)
**de repente** (suddenly)
**desde el primer momento** (from the first moment)
**el otro día** (the other day)
**en ese momento** (at that**esta mañana** (this morning)
**esta tarde** (this afternoon)
**la semana pasada** (last week)
**el mes pasado** (last month) moment)
**entonces** (then)
**el año pasado** (last year)
**hace dos días, años** (two days, years ago)
**ayer por la mañana** (yesterday morning)
**ayer por la tarde** (yesterday afternoon)